
2.4 Unit 2, Option B: British Political History in the 19th Century

Focus

Grounded in an understanding of the relevant chronology, this option concentrates on key developments in 19th century British political history. It places particular emphasis on an understanding in some depth of how and why franchise changes affected wider political developments and how and why the Government responded to pressure for change by creating a framework for the management of poverty and for responding to problems of poverty and low levels of public health. It also gives students the opportunity to understand how pressure for change could influence both the structure and the role of government and political parties in a rapidly growing industrial society.

Clarification of content for each topic can be found in *Appendix 1*.

Students entered for Option B are required to study ONE topic: B1 or B2.

B1 Britain, 1830-85: Representation and Reform

- The Great Reform Act: its immediate causes (from 1830); passage and impact to 1850.
- Chartism: origins of the movement from 1832; course and nature of threat to the authorities; its impact on politics and the political culture of working people.
- Parliamentary reform and redistribution, 1867-85: the causes, significance and impact to 1885 of parliamentary reforms and associated franchise reforms.
- The implications of Parliamentary reform for the development of the Whig/Liberal and Tory/Conservative parties.

B2 Poverty, Public Health and the Growth of Government in Britain, 1830-75

- Reasons for widespread poverty in early 19th century: the operation of the old Poor Law and reasons why it was controversial.
- The Poor Law Amendment Act of 1834 and diverse reactions to it up until 1875.
- The impact of cholera on pressure for public health legislation in the 1830s and 1840s: the role of Edwin Chadwick and John Snow.
- Local public health provision and legislation: reasons for passing the Public Health Act (1848) and reactions to it in the 1850s; reasons for the passing of the Public Health Act of 1875.